
How America's Birthday Got Hijacked

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[Sign up for the Surge](#), the newsletter that covers the most important political nonsense of the week, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

Welcome to this week's edition of the Surge, a newsletter that *could* have beaten Elon Musk to [trillionaire status](#) but is consciously pursuing a slow-growth model instead.

This week, as every week, we check in on the latest primary results, as well as complete our regularly scheduled check-in of California's primary results. Elsewhere, Senate Republicans are at each other's throats and thinking about calling it a year, workwise. Graham Platner's margin in the Maine Senate primary was closely watched, but why? Who knows.

Let's begin with our second-ever, and second consecutive, octogenarian president.

1.

Donald Trump

How America 250 became Trump 80.

We'd like to congratulate President Donald Trump for making it to 80 years old, [a milestone he will celebrate on Sunday](#). More importantly, we'd like to congratulate you, reader, for having successfully cohabitated the Earth with Donald Trump for up to 80 years. The president will celebrate the occasion with a mixed martial arts fight at the White House, for which he's had constructed a metallic eyesore on the people's lawn. Between his own birthday, America's 250th birthday, and the president's having given up on responding to public opinion, Trump is using the powers of the office mostly to entertain himself while he still can.

The fight is the kickoff of a summer of amusements in the nation's capital, ostensibly tied to America 250 but rebranded by the president into celebrations of himself. (More than rebranded: The congressionally authorized group planning the festivities has been shunted aside in favor of [Trump's own group](#).) After the UFC fight, Trump 80 will feature an IndyCar race in Washington, as well as a Great American State Fair, at the president's urging. [Trump is planning](#) a "rally to end all rallies" for late July, replacing the concert series that had been planned before many of the [artists backed out](#). But first: fight night. The forecast calls for thunderstorms.

2.

Spencer Pratt

Yes, "rigged" is the only possible explanation for a Republican to lose in Los Angeles.

We have to offer a mea culpa. [Last week](#), we wrote that it was possible for Democrat Nithya Raman to leapfrog past Republican Spencer Pratt into the top two in Los Angeles' mayoral race as counting continued, but that the odds were against it. You'll never guess what Raman [did a couple of days](#) later. The [young intern](#) who shot us with a tranquilizer dart and then inserted that inexact analysis apologizes. But the outcome makes sense. L.A. is (famously!) a very blue city; Trump won 26 percent of the vote there in 2024—a higher share than Republican presidential candidates typically receive—and Pratt earned 26 percent, not enough to get past Raman or incumbent Mayor Karen Bass.

And yet, as Slate's [Alex Kirshner explains](#), the sheer level of incredulity from conservatives, who convinced themselves that their Elon Musk-sculpted X algorithms accurately represented public opinion in Los Angeles, has been breathtaking. Fanned by Pratt's own [typically irresponsible posting](#) that he lost because of fraud, it has become an article of faith on the right that the election was stolen from him with zero evidence. Fellas, fellas, fellas! Go ahead and question Angelenos' choices. Call them sheeple in a one-party system who are too brainwashed to understand that this actor from *The Hills* and *The Hills: New Beginnings* had all the ingredients to turn L.A. around. But there's nothing fishy about a Republican coming in third after two Democrats in Los Angeles.

3.

Bill Pulte

An impasse in intelligence.

Last week, when Trump selected Bill Pulte, a partisan pit bull with no intelligence experience, to be the next director of national intelligence, he created another immediate mess in Congress. Section 702 of the Foreign Intelligence Surveillance Act, which authorizes warrantless surveillance under some circumstances, was set to expire again soon. Democratic votes are needed to reauthorize it, and there was no way Democrats would give warrantless-surveillance powers to the guy who spends all day scouring the mortgage applications of Trump's critics for jailable offenses. Later in the week, Trump said that Pulte would serve only on an acting basis for the position. But Democrats wouldn't give "acting" DNI Pulte these powers either.

On Thursday, both the House and Senate failed to pass extensions before heading home for the weekend. As their planes were taxiing, Trump announced that he would nominate Jay Clayton, a U.S. attorney and former Securities and Exchange Commission chairman, to the position permanently. Had he made that announcement a few hours earlier, maybe Congress *could* have passed some sort of brief extension before jetting off. But Pulte holding the job for even one minute will remain a problem for Democrats.

4.

Thom Tillis

Senate Republicans may regret not killing the slush fund.

Senate Republicans were exposed to a number of difficult amendment votes during last week's consideration of their immigration-enforcement reconciliation bill—both from the Democrats and from their own members. North Carolina Sen. Thom Tillis, loosened up by his impending retirement, wrote a letter to his fellow Republicans this week complaining about how poorly managed the amendment process was. We recommend reading the letter, which Punchbowl News [first reported, in full](#). It's rare to see a senator discuss the political strategy around floor votes so candidly in a note that he surely knew would leak. (Also, it's got drama, such as when he takes a shot at Alabama Sen. Tommy Tuberville by bringing up his staffer's dating life. Thom!) The thrust of the letter is that still-lingering fear of Trump exposes vulnerable senators to greater danger in the fall.

One of the main points he makes is that “we missed an opportunity to remove a political albatross (the 1776 Fund) from around the necks of our colleagues who are in cycle. Instead, we added weight to that albatross by having 41 members vote to protect the program.” Most Senate Republicans took the Trump administration at its word that the \$1.8 billion slush fund had been quashed and opted not to use their statutory authority to ensure that. But as the Atlantic [reported this week](#), officials in the administration “are exploring whether elements of the fund can be reactivated while also examining alternative arrangements to make sure loyalists get compensated.” Given how [furious Trump is](#) at the Senate for daring to push back over the slush fund, the requested ballroom funding, and the Pulte nomination, we wouldn't be surprised if Trump revives the fund *for the sole purpose* of humiliating Senate Republicans.

5.

Mitch McConnell

No appetite for another reconciliation bill.

With that ballbuster of a reconciliation bill out of the way, is there another one to go in the final months before the election? Trump is insistent on forcing another one upon his beleaguered enemies in the Senate Republican conference. He [posted this week](#) that he wanted another party-line bill that would include the SAVE America Act, as well as \$350 billion in defense spending, which, when combined with the administration's defense request of \$1.15 trillion through traditional appropriations, would allow the administration to reach its targeted \$1.5 trillion military budget.

We've already done one mea culpa this week and don't want to set ourselves up for another, but: This is supremely unlikely, for basically every reason. Senators are *spent* after the previous reconciliation bill and don't want to further endanger their vulnerable members. The SAVE America Act, an elections policy bill, cannot fit within the tax-and-spend strictures of the budget reconciliation process and may not have enough organic support anyway. Defense appropriators hate the idea of funding the military via reconciliation, since it's a one-time sugar rush of dollars rather than a long-term investment in defense base budget. Then, of course, there's the problem that Republicans in both chambers, with their tight margins, can barely pass anything, let alone a package with

numerous controversial provisions.

Take it from Sen. Mitch McConnell, who's lost a step or two but still knows how to read the room of his fellow Republicans better than anyone. "I think it's safe to conclude there will not be another reconciliation bill," McConnell, the top defense appropriator in the Senate, said during a hearing this week.

6.

Graham Platner

What does his primary win margin mean? That he won the primary.

The Surge must tip its cap to the many political reporters who convinced their editors that they needed to visit beautiful summertime Maine this week to cover an effectively uncontested primary. Also to have a few beers by the water—for journalism. The narrative they constructed was that the margin by which Graham Platner won over Gov. Janet Mills, who suspended her campaign months ago but remained on the ballot, and other also-rans was critical in determining Platner's strength following a series of scandals over the past couple of weeks. A few days of monitoring the situation from Bar Harbor would be necessary.

Platner won the primary with 72 percent of the vote to Mills' 19, while a third candidate, David Costello, earned 8 percent. What does that 72 percent *mean* for Platner? Well, according to a cable news roundtable we watched, that cleared the 70 percent bar that sources, who pulled that number out of their ass, said would qualify as a strong showing from Platner. So everything's all right! Reminder: Democrats can name a new candidate if Platner withdraws by July 13. We don't expect it to come to that. What we are asking you to do, though, is circle July 14 on your calendars as the day that Republicans' really good opposition research on him will drop.

7.

Nancy Mace

Well ... it was worth a shot?

South Carolina held its primaries on Tuesday, and before we get to the main event, may we just say: Lindsey Graham [getting only 57 percent](#) of the GOP Senate primary vote, with Trump's endorsement, and against a couple of nobodies is an impressively weak performance. But to the main event: the governor's race. Trump-endorsed Lt. Gov. Pam Evette and state Attorney General Alan Wilson advanced to a runoff. What's more notable is who didn't: Rep. Ralph Norman, a Freedom Caucus mainstay who had endorsed Nikki Haley in the 2024 Republican presidential primary, something Trump did not forget, came in third. And Rep. Nancy Mace, the most attention-hungry Republican member of the United States Congress, came in a distant fifth.

We have [written a bit](#) about Mace and the self-destruction she'll put herself through to satisfy an unhealthy need for camera time. It's best for everyone, Mace included, that she take a breather to touch grass. We will say, though, that she foreclosed on the possibility of a Trump endorsement—and with it a chance to win the race—when she signed the discharge petition to force a vote on releasing the Epstein files, and that took some courage. Anyway: bye!

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